energy matrix depends on coal, a greater contaminant than petroleum. At the beginning of 2013 the unprecedented fact could be observed that one-third of China was underneath a carbon dioxide cloud. This was repeated midway through the year when serious samples of pollution forced millions of Chinese to suspend activities.

According to the World Health Organisation (WHO), this level of air pollution has never been known. According to the WHO, half a million people have died from atmospheric contamination since 2008, mainly from respiratory diseases and cancer (Lander 2013). Air pollution has generated unheard-of protests in China, where thousands and sometimes tens of thousands have manifested their rejection of polluting factories, waste incinerators and, above all, the lack of state environmental policies. Besides causing socio-environmental problems, the ecological crisis has forced many industries to stop production on the days of worst pollution.

We see then that Chinese economic growth has been checked by the following limitations: the first consists of the population's resistance to the model of over-exploitation and deprivation, and the consequent demonstrations; the second is the health and other problems arising from pollution; and the third is the genuine lack of hydrocarbons and other strategic resources. Although China recently showed possibilities of resolving some of the social aspects of the crisis temporarily, at least those that have to do with over-exploitation, others remain that do not seem to have solutions, at least in the medium to long term.

Chinese geopolitical oil strategies

One of the best ways to understand the role that China has chosen as an emerging power is to be found in its strategies to guarantee access to natural resources. This begins with studying its policy of alliances and conflicts with Europe and the United States, the other members making up the BRICS countries (Brazil, Russia, India, China and South Africa) as well as those in its sphere of influence and in distant places that have welcomed it, such as Africa.

Since the 2008 crisis, the Chinese economy has continued to develop in absolute terms, making it possible to predict that it may become the next world hegemonic power towards the 2050s.[2] However, there are some constraining factors, among which perhaps the most important is petroleum. Twenty-five years ago China was the major oil exporter to all of East Asia (Ricaurte 2012); today it is an oil importer in second place behind the United States. For China, perhaps more than any other country, petroleum is a fundamental input in manufacturing and construction. Scarcity of this resource has already occasioned